The rationale for taxing sugar-sweetened beverages.

The diet and diseases related to diet, such as obesity which is one of the most significant public health problems in twenty-first century, arouse great attention. Among all the factors, the overconsuming of sugar sweetened drinks should be attached with a great significance because it contains too much free sugar and doesn't make people feel full. In this essay, it will be argued that the sugar sweetened drinks should be taxed by governments to lower its consumption. Not only the income from the tax could be used for the public health project, but also enterprises will adjust the behavior of enterprises in order to create a more healthy product.

First, based on our experience taxes affect the reduction of sugary drinks consumption. For instance, following the imposition of a one penny per ounce tax in Mexico there was on average a reduction of 7.6 percent in purchases of taxed drinks in 2 years (more reduction in poorer households). (Colchero et al., 2016). Also, in another example, the possible strategies of pricing in the UK show that a tax of twenty percent would decrease approximately obesity prevalence by 1.3 percent in adults. They will prevent approximately 180,000 cases with this strategy. (Mytton et al., 2012). Therefore, people can be guided well with price signals to avoid consumption of damaging products.

Secondly, the revenue of the tax can be used specifically for the funding of health promotion activities. In the case of Berkeley in California, the first city in the US to introduce a tax on soda, the funds are being directed towards school nutrition programmes and community health projects. This adds to the effectiveness of the policy in an overall sense (Falbe et al., 2016). With specific earmarking of the revenue generated from the tax, this can focus on the areas where the consumption of sugary drinks is the highest. And this is the areas where there is a prevalence of diet related disease. So by earmarking the revenue, it can focus on the areas where both health promotion activities and the equity aspect can be addressed at the same time.

Sugar taxes are often criticised as being regressive and paternalistic as they are more financially punishing for the poorer consumers. This does carry some weight but misses two important points; the health burden of consuming sugary drinks is in itself regressive and more punishing for the poor and the potential for progressive spending of the tax income to counteract the additional spending. Also, the evidence from industry response to taxes shows that the impacts aren't all about paternalism, over half of the products are reformulations to reduce sugar content in response to the UK tax which means the benefit is to all consumers regardless of whether they change their buying behaviour (Bandy et al., 2020).

Conclusion To sum up, a proportional and evidence-based approach to a major public health issue is the taxation of sugar-sweetened beverages. Less consumption of sugar-

sweetened beverages when voluntary measures were not successful. It pays for further health programmes. It encourages healthier reformulations. It is now the moment for the slow response governments to realize that it's not anymore "Does the taxation of sugar-sweetened beverages work?" but "How to do it fairly?"

References

Bandy, L. K., et al. (2020). Reductions in sugar sales from soft drinks in the UK from 2015 to 2018. BMC Medicine, 18(1), 20.

Colchero, M. A., Rivera-Dommarco, J., Popkin, B. M., & Ng, S. W. (2017). In Mexico, evidence of sustained consumer response two years after implementing a sugar-sweetened beverage tax. Health Affairs, 36(3), 564-571.

Falbe, J., et al. (2016). Impact of the Berkeley excise tax on sugar-sweetened beverage consumption. American Journal of Public Health, 106(10), 1865-1871.

Mytton, O. T., Clarke, D., & Rayner, M. (2012). Taxing unhealthy food and drinks to improve health. BMJ, 344, e2931.